

used — 204 times, at a strike rate of 145.58 — but is becoming more a fashionable choice. Kyle Jamieson, Jofra Archer, and Kagiso Rabada are some frontline bowlers who have incorporated the variation into their arsenal, and it won't be long before more follow suit.

The need for variation has not been lost on the tweekers either, though how those variations have evolved has been a tale in itself.

T20 demanded variation from spinners much earlier. Over time, those who could turn the ball both ways were preferred over regulation finger spinners. In T20Is since 2020, four of the five bowlers who have bowled the most deliveries are leg-spinners — Adam Zampa, Wanindu Hasaranga, Adil Rashid, and Ish Sodhi.

But batters daring to employ horizontal-bat shots have added another layer of filtration. Its effect will be evident at the upcoming World Cup in the form of mystery spinners. Since the tournament's last edition, they have emerged as among the most trusted options.

Varun Chakaravathy leads this pack by some distance. In T20Is since July 2024, he has opted for a variation on 47 per cent of his deliveries — nearly every alternate ball. Abrar Ahmed of Pakistan, though branded a leg-spinner, has enough variety to pull off the mystery gambit. He is second in terms of variation usage, throwing a curveball every fourth delivery.

The resurgence of the arm-ball has also equipped spinners to deal better. In T20Is in 2025, it was

used more than 500 times, with bowlers snaffling 45 wickets at an average of 11. The numbers were slightly better in 2024 — 53 wickets at an average of 10. The arm-ball has worked particularly well for Akeal Hosein. Pairing it with his regular left-arm orthodox, he has used the variation 126 times since the last World Cup, conceding under six an over.

Yet, despite the rich range, safety may still be elusive for bowlers if dew plays a major role at the World Cup.

In a format that demands constant refinement, batters undoubtedly hold an edge. Factors like ground sizes and dew only exacerbate the predicament for bowlers.

But therein lies the spectacle — batters pushing to tilt the game in their favour, and bowlers striving to bridge the gap as much as possible.

For cricket, a game of fine margins, the current T20 template is a reminder of its own adage.



Against the norm: In T20Is since July 2024, Varun Chakaravathy has opted for a variation on 47 per cent of his deliveries. K. R. DEEPAK

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